NGO SUPPORT TOOLKIT · 02

Grant Proposal Template and Guide

A section-by-section structure most funders recognise, with prompts for what to write in each part, a checklist for before you submit, and the mistakes that sink most proposals.

Free to use and adapt **For** anyone writing a grant application swkghana.org/support · October 2026

HOW TO USE IT

- Always follow the funder's own form first. Use this to fill the gaps.
- Copy the headings into your document and answer each prompt.
- Word counts are guides. Keep to the funder's limits.

THE GOLDEN RULE

Write for a busy reader who knows nothing about you. Every section should answer one question: why should *this* funder back *this* work, now?

1 The proposal, section by section

Cover page

1 page

Project title, your legal name and registration number, contact person, amount requested, project length, location, and a one-paragraph summary (around 100 words).

Executive summary

200–300 words

The whole proposal in miniature. Write it last.

- The problem and who it affects
- What you will do, and what will change as a result
- Why you are the right organisation, and how much it costs

About your organisation

200–400 words

Mission, years active, people reached so far (with numbers), relevant past projects, partners, and how you are governed. Funders look for evidence that you can deliver and account for their money.

The problem

300–500 words

- What is the problem, and how do you know? Cite data, for example from the Ghana Statistical Service, and your own experience.
- Who is affected, where, and how many people?
- What causes it, what has been tried, and why is now the moment to act?

Who will take part

150–300 words

Who the project is for, how many people, how you will reach and select them, and how they helped shape the project. Say how you will include women, people with disabilities and others who are often left out.

Goal and objectives

100–200 words

One overall goal, then two to four objectives that are **specific, measurable, achievable, relevant and time-bound**. For example: *"By June 2027, 200 young farmers in the Eastern Region will have a written business plan."*

2 Plan, results and money

Activities and timeline

Activity	Objective	Months (e.g. 1–3)	Lead

Results and how you will measure them

Result	Indicator	Baseline	Target	Data source

Tip: count outputs (people trained) but promise outcomes (what changed for them). Toolkit 03 covers indicators in depth.

Monitoring, evaluation and learning

150–300 words

How you will collect data, how often, who is responsible, how you will report to the funder, and how you will use what you learn to improve the project.

Budget summary

Category	Requested	Other funding	Total
Staff and fees			
Activities and materials			
Travel and transport			
Equipment			
Monitoring and evaluation			
Administration (overheads)			
Total			

Add a short note justifying each line. The budget must match the activities: every activity should have a cost, and every cost should link to an activity.

Sustainability 100–250 words

What continues after the grant ends, and who pays for it? Think skills, partnerships, local ownership and other income.

Risks and how you will manage them

Risk	Likelihood	Impact	What you will do

Safeguarding, partners and attachments

How you keep participants safe (name your policy and safeguarding lead), what each partner does, and the documents you are attaching.

3 Before you submit

- [ ] You meet every eligibility rule, and you have read the funder's priorities.
- [ ] Every question is answered, within the word limits.
- [ ] The budget adds up, and matches the narrative.
- [ ] Names, numbers and dates are the same in every section.
- [ ] Attachments ready: registration certificates, NPO licence, audited accounts, board list, key policies, letters of support.
- [ ] Someone outside the project has read it for clarity.
- [ ] Submitted a day early, in the right format and time zone.

Why proposals fail. Ignoring what the funder says it funds. A vague problem with no evidence. Activities that don't lead to the promised results. A budget that doesn't match the plan. Missing the deadline. **Rejected?** Ask politely for feedback, and use it to make the next one stronger.

4 Where to look for funding

Free places to find calls for proposals and partners. Check each funder's eligibility rules before you apply.

UN Partner Portal
Register once to see and respond to UN agencies' calls for civil society partners. unpartnerportal.org

STAR-Ghana Foundation
A Ghanaian foundation that supports civil society through grants and capacity building. star-ghana.org

GlobalGiving Accelerator
Training plus a crowdfunding campaign for vetted non-profits. globalgiving.org/accelerator

Candid Learning
Free courses on proposal writing and fundraising. learning.candid.org

EU Funding & Tenders Portal
Every European Union call for proposals, including for civil society. ec.europa.eu/info/funding-tenders

Global Fund for Community Foundations
Grants and support for community-led organisations. globalfundcommunityfoundations.org

Opportunity Desk
A regularly updated list of grants, fellowships and awards. opportunitydesk.org

More free resources
Our full, regularly reviewed list. swkghana.org/support

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